

After the release of Russell's theory of definite descriptions – descriptions starting with the word 'the' – philosophers attempted to exploit certain problems found that Russell seems to have overlooked. One of these philosophers was Keith Donnellan, and he believed that Russell explained only half of the story. In his paper "Reference and Definite Descriptions", Donnellan states that there are two uses of definite descriptions – the "attributive" and the "referential" (285), and that Russell failed to address the latter. Because of this, Donnellan believes he has found legitimate counterexamples to Russell's theory, that is, until another philosopher, Saul Kripke, came along and devised a sort of Grice (yet another philosopher) "test" (265) to see if Donnellan's findings were sound or not. With this, Donnellan's view of definite descriptions will first be explained, followed by why he believes that the referential use of definite descriptions act as counterexamples against Russell's theory; and finally Kripke's "test" will be laid out, leading to his conclusion that Donnellan's claims cannot be counterexamples to Russell theory on the grounds that they do not pass his "test".

Donnellan sees definite descriptions in a different light than Russell. As stated, in Donnellan's view, there are two ways that a definite description can be used: the first being the "attributive" use – on this view Donnellan says, "A speaker who uses a definite description attributively in an assertion states something about whoever or whatever is the so-and-so." (285) – the second being the "referential" use, where Donnellan exhausts, "A speaker who uses a definite description referentially in an assertion, on the other hand uses the description to enable his audience to pick out whom or what he is talking about and states something about that person or thing". So, from the scope of the referential use, an object is *referred* to by the speaker in a way that the audience should be able to understand what object is being referred to; and then an expression is made referring to said object. Think of Donnellan's example of the *Individual with*

*the Martini Glass*. Do we know that the person is really drinking a martini when we say something like “Who is that drinking a martini by the stage?”? At the very least, people seem to know who is being referred to. .

Donnellan makes the claim that “the referential use of definite descriptions is not recognized in Russell's view.” (281) Donnellan believes that a sentence can be true even if the stated definite description in the sentence fails to refer to an object – or fails to *denote* an object, to use Russellian terminology. Let’s take the sentence, “The King of France is bald.” Using Russell-English, this would read as “Someone is a King of France, and no one else is a King of France, and this someone is also bald.” This separates the direct connection between the definite description, “The King of France”, and the phrase that it denotes, “is bald.” This is to make clear that the definite description doesn’t mean, in terms of itself, anything, and even more importantly, “The King of France” doesn’t mean “is bald”. Yet, when expressed using Russell’s tedious framework, we see that there is in fact someone that is a “King of France” and that this someone is “also bald”. Though things seem satisfied, Russell would say this is a false sentence as there is no “King of France” in actuality. But, let us say for example that there is a President of France. Now imagine attending a meeting with a family member where you see this President of France together. The family member says to you, “The King of France is bald.” – to which you reply with “They don’t have a king, they have a president.” This still assumes that the family member knew who was being referred to, even though the definite description was incorrect. And this is why Donnellan believes that Russell’s theory doesn’t account for the “referential use” (285) of definite descriptions.

So what exactly is Kripke’s “test”? The idea is this: if allegations are made towards “a certain linguistic phenomenon in English” (265) being a “counterexample to a given analysis”

(265), Kripke poses a hypothetical language that is close to English but “the analysis is stipulated to be correct”. (265) Kripke argues that “if the phenomenon in question would still arise in a community that spoke such a hypothetical language... the fact that it arises in English cannot disprove the hypothesis that the analysis is correct for English.” (265)

Kripke wants to see if “the phenomena Donnellan adduces” (267), regarding Russell’s theory of definite descriptions, “would arise in a hypothetical society” (267), that spoke a hypothetical language – a language where Russell’s analysis is taken to be correct. Kripke highlights three types of this language: the “weak Russell language”, the “intermediate Russell language”, and the “strong Russell language”. (265) If the phenomena does appear to show itself in both the hypothetical language(s) like it does in English, then it isn’t correct to assume a counterexample against Russell’s theory. He states first that “the weak Russell language” is like that of English, with the difference being for sentences containing definite descriptions, their “truth conditions...are stipulated to coincide with Russell’s”. (265) The “intermediate Russell language” is a bit more complex. Here Kripke highlights that “sentences containing definite descriptions are taken to be abbreviations or paraphrases of their Russellian analyses”. (265) This then leaves the “strong Russell language” where it would seem that “definite descriptions are banned from the language” (265) altogether.

So, why does Kripke believe that the referential use of definite descriptions fails as a counterexample to Russell’s theory regarding the same matter? Kripke states that the proposed phenomena by Donnellan would happen in a society where the inhabitants spoke any of the three types of Russellian languages listed. “Surely speakers of these languages are no more infallible than we” (265), he expresses. We don’t necessarily speak Russell-English, where everything is laid out extensively, and sometimes to the degree that the word ‘the’ must vanish. We speak what

can be called “conversational English” or something of the sort, and certain phenomena arise when language is used. But the same phenomena have been shown to arise when put up against the Russell languages, if we spoke them. And since the expression in English of such phenomena would arise too in any of the forms of Russell-English, this “provides no argument against the hypothesis that English is a Russell language.” (267) Therefore, Kripke concludes that Donnellan has made an incorrect assertion regarding the referential use of definite descriptions being counterexamples against Russell’s theory.